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Mona Hinton

Mona Hinton is half of the jazz world's most beloved couple. She has helped direct the marvelous career of her husband Milt Hinton, and acted as a business advisor to Count Basie as well as music contractor for Lena Horne, Quincy Jones and Sammy Davis. Along the way, Mona received a Master's Degree in Education, while serving as a support system for many struggling jazz artists in New York City.

Mona was interviewed by Milt Fillius and Dr. Michael Woods in Scottsdale, Arizona on March 4, 1995. At the festival she received the distinction as the first non-performer to ever be chosen as the festival's "Guest of Honor."

MF: We are about to do another videotape interview for the Jazz Archive of Hamilton College. We are very fortunate today to have with us Mona Hinton, who is the mother of all the jazz musicians in the U.S.A. She's married to Milt, and very much acts the part and is the perfect musician's wife. It's a joy indeed to have her here representing all those great musicians' wives. Mona, how are you today?

MH: I'm doing fine.

MF: You're doing fine, okay. And you're being honored here at the Scottsdale Jazz Party at the Paradise Valley that is, and you are being honored, as was Milt some years ago, and I guarantee you it's the only husband and wife team that will ever be honored in jazz, right?

MH: Yes, well I have to — I must preface this — the reason I'm wearing my sweatshirt today that was specially designed for me. I think this is the eighteenth party that Don and Susan have given, and each year they've always honored a male musician. And I'm very happy to say that I am the first non-musician and the first female to be honored at this party so I think it's quite an honor.

MF: You have a lovely daughter, and a granddaughter whom I know you idolize, Inez. And I'm not going to ask you how she is because that would mean that we'd use the rest of the tape listening to stories about Inez. But I hope she is well.

MH: She is doing fine.

MF: Tell us what it's like to be the wife of a jazz musician, the most popular one of all besides.

MH: Well I must say the good Lord's been very good to us. Milt and I have been together over fifty years, and I must tell you that all the young wives, not all of them, but many of the young wives and the young musicians insist that they're going to start what you call a 101 — is that the survey course you take when you start the college — but this is going

a lot of little things that you should know when you start out on the road. Fortunately, in the early 50's I used to work in Chicago and they had this famous hotel there, the DuSable Hotel, and I worked there and it gave me an opportunity to meet a lot of the musicians. So I go back a long way. As I say it's just been beautiful. I mean I've had a chance to meet all the musicians, and all the years that I was traveling with Milton with Cab Calloway's band, I was the only female who traveled all the time, and I was like the den mother. I used to save their money — those who would drink and couldn't handle it, I'd take their money away from them at night, and then when they got sober the next morning I'd return it to them. And I was just considered the den mother, and down through the years I've had this great opportunity to meet many, many, many, many families and I have extended families all over the world. As a result, I mean, I've just been Milton Hinton's wife. So I don't know what else you want me to —

MF: Tell me of the early days, when you traveled with the Calloway band, there were some problems, weren't there? Racial problems?

MH: Oh, yes, big problems.

MF: Tell us about those.

MH: Well, unfortunately, due to the climate of our society, you know that we had, the blacks and the whites were segregated. And it made it very difficult, especially when we were traveling in the south. Because frequently we would run into Glenn Miller's band or Tommy Dorsey's band, or some of the well known white bands. They were staying in nice hotels. And unfortunately the black musician would have to stay on the other side of the tracks, usually in someone's home, or in a hotel that was not very good. And as I say unfortunately, frequently the owners of the hotels, they would take advantage I mean of the black musicians. They knew that we could not stay in places, and we'd run into places with rats and with the roaches and with the bed bugs and whatnot. So under those circumstances it was not good. Frequently we would go in towns and I would have to go out in the black community and try to help find rooms for the musicians in Calloway's band, and sometimes it was very, very, the places where we had to eat were just intolerable. And as I say, we made it.

MF: Didn't Calloway finally get a railroad car?

MH: Well see Calloway's band would be in the Cotton Club for six months. And then, they'd keep the same show in the Cotton Club for six months and then that show would travel for six months. And so we would go from here, you know, and stop, making all the little stops going down to the south, and that's when he had a Pullman. He had this big Pullman with an extra car where all the musicians had their trunks. Milton and I, we always had lower seven berth, but then there was a car next to that, and you had your

dressed and go out. Because that way it alleviated the necessity of having to try to find places to stay and we would go to California using the Pullman. And coming back — oh and I must say Cab had his big automobile on the car, on the Pullman, it was really nice. And then coming back we would hire, he would hire a Greyhound bus, a very nice bus. We were fortunate that we never had to travel in cars like most of the other musicians in those days. They had to pile in automobiles. But Calloway was first class all the way. He was always first class. And coming back we would have a bus and we used to keep the same driver, the same bus, and work our way back down through the south and back to New York. And it's kinda funny that we had this one bus driver for quite a long time, and instead of sleeping when he was supposed to be sleeping while the band was playing, he would be partying. So it was my job, I had to sit up in the seat right behind him and keep him awake until daybreak, and then Mr. Wright, who was the road manager, then he'd come and he would sit up there, sit up there with him and then I could go take a nap. But it was fun. It was really fun as I say, and I was always the only female traveling with the band all the time. So I was the den mother.

MF: What other stories do you remember about those days with the Cab Calloway band? There must have been lots with the characters that were in that band.

MH: Yes but you see the first, when I first started traveling with Milton he said, "you're going to be the only female here, and the wives will come out on occasion," and he said, "if I ever hear you say that much about what the husbands are doing on the road," he said, "I'm going to cut your tongue out." And I believed him. So I never, and quite naturally the wives would come out and they'd try to pick me to try to find out what their husband were doing, but they never got anything out of me.

MF: That's wonderful. We let's see, did you have favorite musicians? You must have. I know that Ben Webster was one that's held in high regard by your husband anyway.

MH: Yeah, well Ben was one of them. I did have favorites.

MF: Tell us who the favorites were.

MH: I don't remember.

MF: Oh, yes you do.

MH: I don't remember. Ben was, well Ben stayed at our house on occasion.

MF: I see.

MH: And he was such a great talent. And it was unfortunate that Milton was working, Milton was working for scale, but Ben, as I say he was a great talent, but he never felt that he could work for scale and so consequently he didn't work a lot of time. And I think I had a great influence on Ben before he left the United States to go to Europe to live, because I sat him down one day and explained to him, my daughter's going to school, and Milton's

Ben, you have an obligation to fulfill because God gave you a great talent. And it was so cute about two days later he came back and he brought a bank book to show me that he was really going to try, you know, to save some money and try to get himself together. But it was difficult. He was such a great talent, and I couldn't understand that he would see a lot of the white musicians who were not nearly as talented as he was, and they were getting names, you know, and getting records made and you know, being put high up, higher up on a planet, not a planet, but I mean in a higher place, you know, plane, and he resented this. And he couldn't handle it. I found that was true with a lot of the black musicians who were really qualified but they could never get anyplace.

MF: Wasn't Doc Cheatham in that band too?

MH: Doc was in the band, Doc had left the band when I was there because Dizzy was there.

MF: I know Dizzy was.

MH: If I'm not mistaken I think Dizzy replaced Doc. I'm not sure, don't quote me, but I think —

MF: I understand Dizzy and Cab had an altercation. Can you tell us that story?

MH: Well, it seemed that they had a little group called the, what was the name of it Cab Jivers. And they would come out and perform. And Dizzy and — I really should let Milton tell that story because he knows the details of it more. But I can remember because a spitball fell in the spotlight. And Cab accused Dizzy of throwing the spitball. And Dizzy was always doing something wrong. But this was one time he was right. He really hadn't thrown the spitball, and I'm not going to go into detail to explain who did throw it, because he never admitted that he threw it, but everyone knew who it was. Yeah, and Cab and Dizzy had this little scuffle and Dizzy stuck his knife in Cab's leg, and I think Milton broke it up. And then Benny Payne and Chu Berry and some of the others came and, as Milton calls them, Pachyderms, they came and broke it up. But Cab and Dizzy, they became friends, I mean they didn't hold grudges for a long time. But as I say I should let Milton tell that story because he knows, and you know Milton is a great storyteller anyway.

MF: Well we intend to get Milton in this series, don't worry, but what we would like to do is have Joe Williams do it. Because Joe and Milton I've heard them together and they're unbelievable, the stories they tell.

MH: Well they go back a long time from when they were youngsters in Chicago.

MF: That's right. And one of the things that we're doing in this series, initially, is we're trying to develop some history of the Basie band. Now two things occur to me. First, the area in which you live is the same area that Basie lived in.

MH: We lived right around the corner from each other before they moved down to Freeport.

MH: Oh, at one time we had oodles of — well Illinois Jacquet and Wild Bill Davis still live near there. But we had Lena Horne lived there, and Ella Fitzgerald and oh gosh, who else? What's his name, James Brown moved there later, Cootie Williams, I can't remember, there was Jackie Robinson and Roy Campanella lived right down the street from us. I know I'm going to miss somebody.

MF: Did you ever have a jam session in the middle of the street?

MH: No because everyone was going his different way. It's probably seldom that they were ever home at the same time.

MF: Now am I correct that you are, were involved with the Basie estate?

MH: Yes, I'm the co-executor of Basie's estate and his wife's estate, and the co-guardian of his daughter Diane.

MF: His daughter's still in a home?

MH: No, we have a home for her in Hollywood, Florida.

MF: Oh, wonderful.

MH: But she has her own home. She lived in, see they had moved to Freeport, down in the Bahamas for about 13 years before they died. So now Diane is back in the States and she's down in Florida.

MF: Now tell me about the picture that is now making the rounds, of all the musicians, that you gave me a copy of that picture some years ago, and now it's in a movie and you're mentioned as being one of the photographers. Can you tell us about that?

MH: Yes. *Esquire* wanted that picture, I think it was 1956 or 1958 —

MF: 57.

MH: 57? Well anyway, they had asked all the musicians, contacted lots of musicians who were in New York and asked them to come to this particular address in front of the brownstone to get this picture for *Esquire* magazine. And Milton had two still cameras, he was shoot, shoot, shooting away, and he had a little eight millimeter movie camera, and he asked me, he gave it to me and said, you know take some footage while the musicians are greeting each other. So that's what I did. And it just so happened that that was the only movie film that was taken that day. So it was very important because they had so many stills, but this way it allowed them to animate the still pictures, and so it was very important. So that's how I happened to get in on that.

MF: It's a marvelous picture. Mike have you seen that picture? Would you like to ask Mona a question?

MW: I'd just wanted to ask you about, you know, Milt has this incredible collection of photos that is like an essay, a photo essay on jazz history. I wanted to ask you about that. As he was taking the pictures, and as you saw this compiling, did you realize that you were

MH: You mean that particular picture?

MW: No, not that single picture, but all the pictures he's taken over the years.

MH: Milton just loved to take pictures. On the road he and Keg Johnson, his dear friend, used to set up a darkroom in the bathroom in the theater or maybe the hotel where we were, and he took hundreds and hundreds of pictures. We never realized they would be that important because half the time he'd throw them in the drawers, and some of them had been taken and not developed for years. And then not only that we had a couple of floods in our basement and it wiped out a lot of our color photos and a lot of the other pictures. But they were just pictures. I mean he never in his wildest dreams ever dreamed that they would become this popular, or this important to the history of the music and the climate of our society, I mean in the United States in general. So I know that you're familiar with the pictures of colored entrance and for colored only, and, but he was just taking pictures I mean for no particular reason other than the fact that he liked, and he's not really a photographer you know, I mean he never studied photography or that kind of thing.

MF: He's better than most who have though.

MH: Yes. He has frequently made this statement and it's true that he's been able to get a lot of pictures that the professional photographers couldn't get because if a professional comes up, you know, you're going to freeze or pose or something. Well he was one of the musicians in the studios or wherever they were, so he's just snap, snap, snapping away, and I mean they wouldn't pay him any attention. So that was why he was able to get a lot of pictures that are really very famous now and I think, of the people who eventually became legends in the business.

MW: And catching people in very natural settings.

MH: Exactly. Because I have to tell you a cute story. You know he takes pride in catching people asleep. So the year before last on the S.S. Norway they had us up so early to get off the ship and we waited and we waited and we waited and we waited. So there was a chaise lounge there, so he crawled up there and went to sleep. I was so tired I crawled up behind him and I went to sleep. Well I tell you they tell me the cameras were clicking like crazy. They finally got us. And I'm telling you I must have had twenty different photos of the two of us there sound asleep. That was to get back at us at that point.

MW: I wanted to ask you about the Basie band. There were obviously some characters in the Basie band, and I was interviewing another one of the people and asking, you know, they were more than just musicians who could play the notes. They were personalities. They were characters. Can you tell us some of the either more funny things that happened or some of the more poignant things that happened in the Basie band amongst the characters?

MH: Well you see I never traveled with the Basie band. See Milton was with Calloway for about 15 or 16 years. So I was always with the Cab Calloway band. So but the Basies and us we were friends and we were neighbors, and I frequently, well Catherine loved, they had a beautiful backyard with an Olympic-sized swimming pool and whatnot. And she loved to give parties for a lot of charitable organizations. And I do remember on one occasion that Milton, and Bill, I call him Bill, but Basie would come over to our house, and he and Milton would sit in the basement and yak and we had this old piano, and he'd play like they used to do in the silent movies and whatnot. And so they were sitting down there one day and the band didn't show up at Catherine's party. So she came and she says "Bill you have to come, you have to come, you and Hinton" (she always called him Hinton). "You and Hinton have to come." And so well they weren't too happy about that. But there they are down there playing all these old, what do you call that music, like for the background for the silent movies? And he had to drop everything and go running back home, to play some music for her garden party. But as I say so I really don't know too much about what happened there. I could tell you about the Calloway band.

MF: I was going to say, what about some funny stories or poignant tales about the Calloway group?

MH: Well I have to tell some that I would be telling out of school.

MF: Well we're not going to publicize this.

MH: Oh, whisper to me.

MF: Oh, no, I wouldn't do that to you.

MH: No, gosh, I'd have to think about it.

MF: Well we'll come back to that in a minute. I want to switch you to another phase of your life that I know is important to you, and that's the work that you do with your church and the Mona Hinton Fund and the work that's done with that. And the thing that amazes me about that is that you have time to do it.

MH: Well I'll tell you —

MF: Could you tell us what the work is?

MH: Well I'll tell you that we raised this money, and on Saturdays we have, at our church, the children from first grade on up to college, up through high school, can come and they introduce them to various, well not occupations, just various well they are occupations I guess but that's not the word I wanted to use. But anyway, they are tutored as I say from first grade through the eighth grade, I mean through the high school, and they have a lot of young black young men who are in various professions such as computers and attorneys, I mean, and various professions. And what they do is come and they donate their time to working with these youngsters. And it's, they're just doing a magnificent

I mean improve their, you know, improve their way of wanting to live, their methods and their lifestyles. And basically that's what they're doing.

MF: They're setting an example.

MH: Exactly. As I say, it's doing an excellent job.

MF: But that operation has your name on it.

MH: Yes, well, they surprised me for my birthday last year and sent out money, I mean sent out requests that many of my friends all over the world, and asked them to make donations towards this endeavor, and they raised a lot of money and I must say that I was quite pleased to know that they had thought enough of me to do this. I have — I don't know — I've been very fortunate inasmuch as to begin with that I had the parents that I had. I had a mother and father that had six children, born in Mississippi, and they moved from Mississippi, they got as far as Centralia, Illinois where I was born. They stayed there until I was nine months old. Then we moved to Sandusky, Ohio, which is my home now. But to think that I had parents with very little formal education, who said, "let's try to get North to give our kids a chance." That took a lot of guts. So I think that that in itself tells you what my background is. Because my parents always believed in education and I mean they made it a very, very important part of our lives.

MF: Isn't that Milton's background, too? From Mississippi?

MH: Yes, he's from Mississippi also. But you see Milton's mother and father separated when he was about, I guess very young, just a few months old. This is a cute story that his uncle always tells. Of course his mother denied it. But he says that when they were married that his mother cooked some blackeyed peas one day. And his father said, "oh, gee, these are the most delicious blackeyed peas I've ever tasted." So his mother cooked them every day. And so finally he came home one day and he was tired of blackeyed peas. So he said you know, "gee baby, I told you I liked blackeyed peas but do I have to eat them every day?" So his uncle says that was the last time he saw Milton's father, he was running down the road in a blaze of glory, because in those days they had the kerosene lamps, and she threw the lamp at him. And I know it's probably a story, but anyway it's a cute story. So that's the last, so Milton, he didn't see his son again until Milton must have been in his early 30's, and just by accident Milton ran into him in Memphis, Tennessee.

MF: Oh really.

MH: So he never saw his father from that day until, as I say, until he was about thirty some years old.

MF: I'll be darned. Now —

MH: But I was just saying that I was so fortunate to have the parents that I did, and I think that

many, many years I did not see the necessity of matriculating. Every time I would feel mentally stagnant, I would just go take a course at Hunter or the New School — I don't think they had the New School then — but any school downtown. And I loved anthropology, I took a lot of courses in that; I loved psychology and I took a lot of courses in that; anything that I felt like that I wanted to do. So it was not until later years that one of the teachers at Queens College talked me into matriculating. And I'm glad he did because when I did graduate, I graduated magna cum laude, and for an old lady, that was pretty good.

MF: Marvelous. How much time do you spend on the road now?

MH: Too much.

MF: Yeah I know that, but what percentage of your time? I know I talked to you the other day and you were just back from Hilton Head and here you are in Phoenix, and I suppose you're going to the gig at Palm Beach and the gig at Sarasota.

MH: And St. Louis. And we had just left Wilmington. And I tell you what I've been trying to cut back because you know I haven't been too well.

MF: I know that.

MH: But my doctor has encouraged me to go as much as I can, because this way it, wherever I am I can rest and I can get my meals proper, you know proper meals. And then it still allows Milton to play his music and do his workshops and his clinics, and all the things that are required of him to keep him going. So it's worked out pretty good except that I think that we took on a little too much this year. But I mean we've been on the road as much as 200 days out of the year.

MF: That's a lot.

MH: Yeah. But Milton thrives on it, and as I said we've been together over, well at least fifty-five years and it's very important for him to do this. See Milton believes he's never going to die. He says that he's going to live forever. And I believe him, that's been his basic philosophy, that he, as long as he shares his talents and his knowledge with young people, and those young people continue to carry it on, in that way, he says he'll never die. And he has really spent his lifetime trying to, not really be a role model, he's just being Milton. But in the end I mean that's eventually what he is, I mean to show these young people that you can work with your church, with the Boy Scouts, you can be the best musician in the world, and you can make it. And I'm very fortunate I mean to have been able to work with Milton. We've been able to work together and Milt never wanted to be a band leader, he never wanted to have a lot of money, he believes that money is to be spent, to be used for the good, for somebody's good. And I go along with him on that along those lines. So there's many youngsters that have come through the years that have

that we did for them. Some of them laugh about how I used to put on a big pot of chicken wings and a big pot of red beans and rice and if you ever see Richard Davis, the bass player, that's the first thing he says, "oh Mona makes the best chicken wings in the whole wide world." But you know you made a big pot and stretch it, and we have the basement, and the kids call it the cave, and they, anytime they would come, sometimes they would want to, didn't have money, place to stay, but they could always stay down there as long as they behaved themselves. So as I say we've been very fortunate like that, in order to help a lot of the youngsters.

MF: Yeah. Well you have a long list of them, I know. Did Charlotte ever travel with the band?

MH: No.

MF: You stayed home with her.

MH: Well you see what happened was, we traveled, and then when Charlotte was born, Milton came home and he went into the recording studios. So while, you know, he went on the road to Japan with Louis Armstrong in '53 I believe it was, and he came back and he said he ... Milton had studied with the best teachers in the whole wide world, and really became very proficient on his instrument. But he could not stand to stay in that band and just play the same music day in and day out, it was killing him. So he said he wasn't going on the road with Louis anymore. Well Joe Glaser was his manager at the time. And Joe said, and they're not talking to each other, they're talking to me and I'm talking, you know I'm the go between. But he says, Milton said, "No I'm going to stay home because my daughter's growing up and she's calling everybody daddy but me." So Joe says, "Well I'll tell you what, I will send, Mona tell him that if he will go on the road with Louis I will send a tutor send you and Charlotte and a tutor." So Milton says, "Well he could send a tutor for Mona, for Charlotte, for Milton and anyone else he wants, I'm not going on the road again and play that same music over and over again." But they finally worked it out.

MF: Louis' show was pretty cut and dried, wasn't it?

MH: Oh, yes, they played those same tunes day in and day out. He was such a remarkable man though. And Milton would have loved to continue to work with him.

MF: Oh he loved Louis I know.

MH: Oh, yes, but he just I mean musically he was killing himself. So then when he was in the recording studios, see that's when we stayed home all those years. On occasion he would go out with somebody, but most of the time he stayed home.

MF: Do you know any good stories about Louis that we haven't heard?

MH: No, not really. He was a nice person.

MF: Well didn't he live in the same neighborhood?

MH: Not too far from us. He lived closer to LaGuardia Airport than we did. But and you know to the day he died he would never call me anything but Mrs. Hinton. I used to say "Pops, it's embarrassing, you call all the other wives by their first names," and one day he said to me and I said "why — it's embarrassing to me that you always say 'Mrs. Hinton.'" And he says, with that gravel voice, he said, "you have a baby, you're a lady, I can't call you anything but Mrs. Hinton." And this was typical of him.

MW: I want to ask you a question about him because I was teaching about him in my History of Jazz class. Tell us about his tone.

MF: His what?

MH: On the trumpet?

MW: He had this huge, huge tone. And it was like a signature. You could hear him play just a few notes and you'd know that was him.

MH: Oh sure, well that's true. But you know that's the secret of being, that's the secret that most musicians should have. Because the minute that I hear Milton playing — we'll get back to Louis — but I have to tell you this. The minute that I hear something, I can almost tell you that's Milton Hinton playing, you know why? Because if you notice, see Milton pushed that 16 piece to 17 piece band all those years with Calloway with nothing but a little microphone, you know. So when you hear, you notice it, when you hear him you hear that solid beat, you know what I mean? Whereas you don't hear it in any other musicians, even the bass players along that time, as I say. So that's like your signature. The minute you hear Teddy Wilson, something, that's Teddy Wilson, you know what I mean? But if somebody who is mimicking Teddy, you don't know who in the devil they are. And that's the way it was with Louis. I mean he had this quality of his tone or whatever you — I don't know the exact or precise word to use for it, but the minute you heard it you knew that that was Louis Armstrong. As I say and that's really what all musicians are striving for.

MF: Well all the great musicians you can say it, just this morning I was standing outside the room and I heard a sound and I said that's got to be Buddy Tate.

MH: That's right, that's right.

MF: There's nobody who plays the sax like Buddy Tate.

MH: So that's pretty much why everyone recognized Louis, because that was his signature.

MF: Well I think Milt has a tone too. I can flip on the radio and hear somebody playing and I'll say that's Milt on the bass.

MH: Yes. Well that's the way it is with me.

MF: Well you know him better than I do.

MW: Can I ask you about some of the early days, you know, Milt is probably the most revered

established himself. What were some mile markers? Because I spent some time with Dizzy and he told me of a little time, I ask him when did you think you'd made it. And he told me this is when I thought I was there. Can you tell us a time like that about Milt?

MH: I don't think so because he's still striving. I don't know whether he feels he has reached that point yet or not. I really don't.

MF: He doesn't. I think you're right.

MH: I don't think he does. Because as he says, every time he plays I means he gives it the best shot that he can. And I think he still does that. So I don't really know if he ever feels that he's really made it.

MW: Well I didn't mean that to say in a way that he would relax and say oh I'm there, I don't really have to work anymore, but when he began to get some feedback from other musicians, that hey, you're doing it.

MH: Oh, I think he got that always. In the Calloway band, and then — I'll tell you what happened — he came to New York after he left Calloway's band, and he was walking down the street one day and he ran into Jackie Gleason and his manager Bull. So Jackie, well Milton knew Jackie when he was, when only the musicians were laughing at his jokes, when they used to buy him a drink, so but he, as I said the day he ran into Milton he said to Milton said, "well what are you doing." And Milton says, "well I'm looking for a job." I mean Milt was just freelancing a little bit around because he'd just come off the road. And so Jackie says to Bull he says, "you know we have a record date tomorrow with Bobby Hackett," so he says, you know, "let's get Milt." So Bull says, "you already have a bass player." He said, "Well now we've got two." And he hired Milton to do that record date. Well consequently there were no black musicians were recording in those days like that. And but when he went in, the A&R man and the conductor and everyone saw that Milton was qualified, and this was, a contractor came over and got his name and the address and said well how can I contact you if I need you, and that's how he became involved, because he was qualified. You see it didn't make any difference whenever a contractor would call, it could be, he never asked who it was for. He would call and say, "is Mr. Hinton free at ten o'clock on Tuesday" or whatever it is, and I had an appointment book, and, "yes he's free." "Well have him at RCA Victor or Capitol or Columbia Studio at such and such a time. Now when he left home he didn't know whether it was a rock 'n roll, whether it was with Stravinsky, whether it was with Barbra Streisand, he didn't, or with a — he didn't know who it was for. Guy Lombardo, you know, it could be anybody. And these were the people that he just went there, they put the music up there, and he had to be on time, he says that, not looking for a place to park or not adjusting your strings, when that conductor's baton came down across his nose you

things that got him started. And once they knew that he was qualified, he could read anything, play anything, and so he just started getting more work than he could handle. And then there for a long time, Osie Johnson the drummer, Barry Galbraith, the guitar player, Hank Jones the piano player, and Milton, they would work, they would do at least three sessions a day — 10-1, 2-5 and 7-8 every day. They were called the New York, the New York Rhythm Section. And they did that for years. As I say that's because they were all qualified. They didn't have to ask can you play this or that. It's an interesting thing, what's his name? Lee? Bill Lee's son? Milton just did a date with him last year. He always wanted to do a date with Milton and Milton says, I can't tell you the name of it, but you see Milton made his first recording date in 1930. And he has worked with every group of musicians, every generation, from that day up to the present day. He, well as a matter of fact, last, two weeks ago he did the soundtrack for what is it, "Clockers" that was, what's his name, Lee? What's his name? Bill Lee's son, the movie guy?

MW: Spike?

MH: Spike. He just did the soundtrack for Spike's new movie called "Clockers" I think is the name of it. So since 1930, he has worked with every musician. And I must tell you an interesting story about Quincy. For Milton's 80th birthday I think it was, he sent a home made video, a homemade videotape to the house, and he had someone take it. And he's standing there with his envelope and piece of paper, and he says, "Bring the camera up I want you to be sure and see this, that Milt can see that this is his handwriting and this is his torn check." And he tells a story on this tape saying that on his first recording date that any company allowed him to do under his own name, I don't know whether the copyist messed up or whatever but anyway the date had to go into overtime. The company held him responsible for the overtime, and here is a young kid, his first recording date under his own name, didn't have a dime. And so anyway, he borrowed and stole and got ahold of the money, and he paid every musician the money that was due them. And he says you know every musician took that money except you, Milton, and here's, he reads the letter and he shows Milton the letter that Milton returned to him, and Milton evidently had torn the check and put it in the letter. And he says, "and here's his torn check." He said, "I have had this all these years in the front of my datebook," and he said, "every day that God allows me to get up, I look at this and keep reminding me of what some of my responsibilities are to other young people." Now I think that's a great tribute. But that's really basically the way Milton has always lived. I mean he's always trying to help, you know, promote the young people and encourage them or whatnot, and I think that's the best example of what I'm saying. And I think it's a great honor that he would keep that all these years, and that was one part of his birthday present to Milton, I

MW: I think there's a tremendous message in that —

MF: Well it's a great story.

MW: For musicians, young musicians today, who are hungry for the trappings without affording each other the camaraderie and support. That's what the music is really about. Am I right?

MH: That's right. I've been very fortunate. In the beginning when Milton and I first got together, I used to think that he allowed people to take advantage of him, and boy I'm telling you I didn't like that and I would speak my mind.

MF: You stopped that, kid.

MH: But I'll tell you one day he said to me he said, "I have to tell you something," he said, "when I do something, I do it from my heart," and he said, "and I don't feel that anybody's taking advantage of me. If I do something and someone wants to take that and misuse it or use it in a negative way," he said, "I have nothing to do with it. That's between them and their God. I've done what I think is right." And it took me a long time to understand that but I think I'm a much better person once I started following, thinking along those lines like he did. But it's true. I mean you do what you think is right, and if someone wants to misuse it, you have nothing to do with it, you've done your part.

MF: Well, Mona, we're coming up on 5:30, that's an hour. And we've enjoyed — the nice things about the stories you tell about Milt is that those of us who know you both know that he couldn't be what he is without you.

MH: Yeah. I have to tell you something about, you know I've been knowing Joe for many years too, and Jillean, she's a lovely person, but one of the nicest renditions I think that I remember of Joe Williams is at the White House, for Duke Ellington's 70th birthday that they had there, and Lou Rawls and Billy Eckstine and Joe did a trio. And it was fabulous. If you ever get a chance, you know you should see it.

MF: Of course he and Billy Eckstine were great friends.

MH: Yes, uh huh.

MF: He was really smashed when Billy passed.

MH: Yeah, we go back many, many years.

MF: Well, you're wonderful people and we sure appreciate your taking the time to come over here. You have done a wonderful job representing the ladies of the music world, and thank God there's you because you're the best. Thanks a lot.

MH: Well, I'm the den mother.